firm. There was no firing, though there were plenty of heated exchanges and jostling.

On 25 August, the pushing and shoving war of attrition that had been going on for five years became more serious. In what subsequently came to be known as the Longju incident, a strong Chinese detachment crossed into Indian territory south of Migyitun on the NEFA border and fired without notice on an Indian forward picket. They then tried to arrest the entire twelve-man picket but eight Indian soldiers managed to escape. Thereafter, the Chinese detachment outflanked the Indian outpost at Longju and opened fire at it from a distance of about 700 metres.

The Longju incident made the headlines on 28 August 1959. The newspapers reported that an Assam Rifles post at this small village in the Subansiri division of NEFA was attacked without provocation by the Chinese and the Assam Rifles were compelled to withdraw after suffering casualties. Unable to keep a lid on the deteriorating relationship with China anymore, Nehru was left with no choice but to face Parliament later in the day.

For the first time in twelve years, Nehru was unsure of himself as he rose from the prime minister's seat in the Lok Sabha to face the rest of the House. Clamouring Opposition members who were demanding a statement on the Longju incident fell silent as attention turned to the prime minister. Speaking in his usual clipped style, every word that Nehru uttered stunned the assembled MPs.

For the first time the prime minister admitted to the people of India that serious disputes existed between China and India regarding the India-Tibet border and that several thousand square kilometres of Indian territory in Ladakh, was under Chinese control. He then disclosed the fact that the Chinese had built a highway across the Aksai Chin, adding that the government had thought it fit not to make the disputes public, as that would have made their settlement even more difficult. He then went on to talk of Khenzemane, describing in fair detail what had happened on the border and then finally talked of Longju, where he said that even as he spoke, the problem had yet to be resolved: 'They were in very large numbers, it is difficult to say in what numbers, but they were in some hundreds—200, 300 or even more. They surrounded the picket and apparently apprehended the lot. The outpost is at a place called Longju which is three to four miles from our frontier between India and Tibet as we conceive it.'